PUNJABI COLLECTION

NO. 06



PUNJAB & DELHI DHABA ORIGIN

Paneer Lababdar

Thick, Robust Dhaba-Style Paneer Curry
Heartier Than Butter Paneer

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Paneer Lababdar

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Dhaba's Answer to a Restaurant Classic

Paneer lababdar occupies a distinct place among North India's paneer curries — thicker, more robustly spiced, and less sweet-tangy than butter paneer, it developed within the Punjabi dhaba tradition as a heartier, more filling alternative better suited to a working meal than an occasional indulgence. Its exact origin is harder to pin to one restaurant or chef than butter paneer's well-documented Moti Mahal story, and food historians generally treat it as an evolution within dhaba kitchens rather than a single invention.

The name itself is subject to some folk debate — some trace "lababdar" to a Persian or Urdu root loosely meaning "of the heart" or heartfelt, fitting for a dish built on generous, no-nonsense flavor rather than delicate refinement, while others suggest it may reference a specific chef or restaurant now lost to history. Whatever its exact etymology, the name has stuck to a dish defined by a thick, deeply spiced tomato-onion gravy that clings heavily to each cube of paneer.

Where butter paneer aims for silky, tangy indulgence and shahi paneer for mellow royal richness, paneer lababdar sits firmly in dhaba territory: bold, thick, and generously spiced, designed to be scooped up with roti after a long day rather than sipped delicately from a spoon.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Dhaba's Answer to a Restaurant Classic, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

A Punjabi dhaba staple, developed as a heartier, thicker alternative to restaurant-style butter paneer. Less internationally known than butter paneer or shahi paneer, but a genuine favorite in North Indian homes and roadside eateries. Considered a working person's indulgence — rich and filling rather than delicately refined. A good introduction to dhaba-style Punjabi cooking for those used to more restaurant-polished curries.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	30m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Small saucepan, for boiling the gravy base ingredients
- Blender
- Kadai or wide, heavy-bottomed pan
- Wooden spoon or spatula

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Paneer lababdar keeps refrigerated for 3–4 days and, like most tomato-based curries, tastes very good reheated. It freezes well for up to a month — add fresh cream after reheating if the texture needs a touch of restored richness.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the gravy base

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Tomatoes, chopped	4 medium	400 g	4 medium
Onion, roughly chopped	2 medium	200 g	2 medium
Cashews, raw	2 tbsp	25 g	2 tbsp
Kashmiri dried red chilies	2	2	2
Water, for boiling	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori

For the curry

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Ghee or butter	3 tbsp	45 g	3 chammach
Ginger-garlic paste	1½ tbsp	22 g	1½ chammach
Capsicum (bell pepper), diced	½ cup	60 g	½ katori
Coriander powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Garam masala	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Kasuri methi, crushed	1 tsp	1 g	1 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste
Paneer, cubed	300 g	300 g	300 g
Cream	2 tbsp	30 ml	2 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Kashmiri dried red chilies add color and a mild, fruity heat — if unavailable, use one regular dried red chili plus an extra ½ teaspoon of Kashmiri chili powder for color. Capsicum is a common but optional addition in many dhaba versions; feel free to omit it for a simpler, more traditional gravy. As with the other paneer dishes in this collection, firm tofu can substitute for a different but still satisfying texture.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Building the Thick Gravy Base

01 BOIL THE BASE INGREDIENTS

Combine the chopped tomatoes, onion, cashews, dried red chilies, and water in a saucepan. Bring to a boil and simmer for 12–15 minutes until everything is completely soft.

02 BLEND TO A THICK PUREE

Let cool slightly, then blend to a smooth, thick puree — this base should be notably thicker than the puree used for butter paneer, which is part of what defines lababdar's character.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Building the Thick Gravy Base, continued

Chef tip. don't add extra water while blending — a thick puree here is exactly what you want for the dish's signature heavier consistency.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The puree should be thick enough to hold its shape on a spoon, noticeably heartier than a typical smooth curry base.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Curry

03 BLOOM THE AROMATICS

Heat ghee in a kadai and add the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant. Add the diced capsicum if using, and sauté for 2–3 minutes until slightly softened but still with a little bite.

04 ADD THE PUREE AND SPICES

Pour in the thick tomato-cashew puree along with the coriander powder, garam masala, and salt. Simmer for 10–12 minutes, stirring frequently, until noticeably thickened and the oil separates at the edges.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Curry, continued

05 ADD PANEER AND FINISH

Fold in the paneer cubes and simmer for 3–4 minutes until warmed through. Crush the kasuri methi between your palms and stir in, along with the cream, for a final minute of gentle simmering.

Texture indicator. finished paneer lababdar should be notably thicker than butter paneer, clinging heavily to the paneer cubes rather than pooling loosely.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Thinning the gravy with extra water to make it easier to stir defeats the purpose of this dish — paneer lababdar is meant to be thick and hearty. Keep the heat patient and stir frequently instead of adding water.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with tandoori roti or naan, ideal for scooping up the thick gravy.
- A dhaba favorite alongside dal and a simple onion salad.

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How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl with a visible thick, glossy sheen and a small pat of butter melting on top.

Family Style

- A hearty centerpiece dish for a weeknight dinner, needing little more than bread and a simple salad alongside.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Thickness Right

- Using less water throughout the cooking process, compared to butter paneer, is the key technical difference that defines this dish's character.
- A longer simmer at the puree stage builds a deeper, more concentrated flavor that thin, quickly-cooked gravies can't match.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The thick gravy base can be made up to 3 days ahead and refrigerated separately from the paneer.
- This dish reheats particularly well thanks to its thickness, making it a good choice for meal prep.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some dhaba cooks add a small amount of besan (gram flour), lightly roasted, to further thicken and add a subtle nutty depth to the gravy — an optional technique for an even heartier result.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

350 kcal	12 g	15 g	28 g	3 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with cream, butter, and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Tree nuts. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Paneer Lababdar with Capsicum	the version featured here, with diced bell pepper for texture and color.
Dhaba-Style Paneer Lababdar	an even spicier, less refined version typical of roadside eateries.
Mixed Vegetable Lababdar	the same thick, robust gravy used with mixed vegetables instead of paneer.

How is this really different from butter paneer?

Paneer lababdar uses a thicker, less diluted gravy base with more robust spicing and less cream, giving it a heartier, less silky character than butter paneer's smoother, tangier gravy.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make this ahead for a dinner party?

Yes — the thick gravy base holds and reheats very well, making it an easy make-ahead option for entertaining.

Is this dish very spicy?

It's more robustly seasoned than butter paneer but not necessarily fiery — adjust the chili quantity to your preferred heat level.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Lababdar	a term of debated origin describing this thick, hearty style of curry.
Dhaba	a roadside eatery in North India, closely associated with this dish's development.
Kasuri Methi	dried fenugreek leaves, crushed and added for aroma.
Handi	a traditional narrow-necked pot often used for serving rich curries.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Paneer Lababdar

15m	30m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

GRAVY BASE

Tomatoes	400 g
Onion	200 g
Cashews	25 g
Kashmiri dried red chilies	2
Water	240 ml

CURRY

Ghee or butter	45 g
Ginger-garlic paste	22 g
Capsicum	60 g
Coriander powder	3 g
Garam masala	3 g
Kasuri methi	1 g
Salt	6 g
Paneer	300 g
Cream	30 ml

METHOD

01 **Boil the base ingredients.** Combine the chopped tomatoes, onion, cashews, dried red chilies, and water in a saucepan.

02 **Blend to a thick puree.** Let cool slightly, then blend to a smooth, thick puree — this base should be notably thicker than the puree used for butter paneer, which is part of what defines lababdar's character.

03 **Bloom the aromatics.** Heat ghee in a kadai and add the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant.

04 **Add the puree and spices.** Pour in the thick tomato-cashew puree along with the coriander powder, garam masala, and salt.

05 **Add paneer and finish.** Fold in the paneer cubes and simmer for 3–4 minutes until warmed through.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Tomatoes	400 g	☐ Onion	200 g
☐ Cashews	25 g	☐ Kashmiri dried red chilies	2
☐ Ghee or butter	45 g	☐ Ginger-garlic paste	22 g
☐ Capsicum	60 g	☐ Coriander powder	3 g
☐ Garam masala	3 g	☐ Kasuri methi	1 g
☐ Salt	6 g	☐ Paneer	300 g
☐ Cream	30 ml		

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